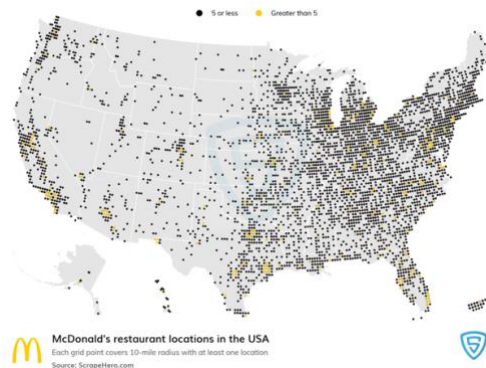


Hook Document: Key Themes in McDonald's Reviews



With the rise of the internet and online platforms for users to openly share opinions, businesses in the restaurant industry rely on online reviews to understand how consumers perceive their products or services, receive information on areas of improvement, and help build their reputation. In 2025, a survey of 1,026 adults in the United States determined that 96% of consumers make a purchase only after reading the corresponding reviews, and 42% trust reviews as much as a friend [1]. In a study on the impact of online reviews and ratings on consumer decisions, it is suggested that positive reviews create a perception of high product quality and reliability, whereas negative reviews lead to doubt and a sense of distrust from the consumer [3].

McDonald's was founded by two brothers, Dick and Mac McDonalds, in San Bernadino, California in 1940, where their idea of the "Speedee Service System" and cheap hamburgers came to life and grew to be the billion-dollar company we are familiar with today [2]. Given McDonald's prominence in the United States, it provides a meaningful case study to use to understand how consumers rate and review business at large, setting a foundation for interesting analyses in human behavior and business development in the restaurant industry.

You are a data scientist tasked with identifying key themes in both positive and negative McDonald's reviews. To accomplish this task, you will use Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), a topic modeling approach, that uncovers latent themes in the reviews. You will then use these resulting themes, along with the customer ratings provided in the dataset, to determine the main themes for positive and negative reviews.

[1] BrightLocal, "Local Consumer Review Survey 2025," BrightLocal Research, 2025. [Online]. Available: <https://www.brightlocal.com/research/local-consumer-review-survey/>.

[2] McDonald's Corporation, "Our history," *McDonald's*, [Online]. Available: <https://corporate.mcdonalds.com/corpmcd/our-company/who-we-are/our-history.html>.

[3] R. Rachmiani, N. K. Oktadinna, and T. R. Fauzan, "The impact of online reviews and ratings on consumer purchasing decisions on E-commerce platforms," *International Journal of Management Science and Information Technology*, vol. 4, no. 2, pp. 504–515, 2024. [Online serial]. Available: <https://doi.org/10.35870/ijmsit.v4i2.3373>.